SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #16 · FAMILY MONEY MESSAGES

“Love is shown through things.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

In some homes, gifts were the main way love was spoken. A parent who worked long hours may have shown care by providing, buying, and fixing, and may have found it hard to say the words. Or a parent who could not afford much may have felt like a failure. Children can learn that love equals what you give or get, and adults can then measure affection by price tags, or feel unloved when the gifts stop.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors generosity, and giving can truly be a way of loving. But Paul says that even if I give all I possess to the poor, but have not love, I gain nothing. John says let us love not in word and speech, but in action and truth. Proverbs says that a dish of vegetables where there is love is better than a fattened ox with hatred. Love often includes gifts, but it is shown most deeply through time, presence, honesty, and faithfulness.

> *“If I give all I possess to the poor and exult in the surrender of my body, but have not love, I gain nothing”* (1 Corinthians 13:3).

Also see

> “Little children, let us love not in word and speech, but in action and truth” (1 John 3:18).

> “Better a dish of vegetables where there is love than a fattened ox with hatred” (Proverbs 15:17).

> “Be devoted to one another in brotherly love. Outdo yourselves in honoring one another” (Romans 12:10).

> “Better a dry morsel in quietness than a house full of feasting with strife” (Proverbs 17:1).

Common self-statements

- If they really loved me, they would buy me this.
- I show my kids I love them by giving them things.
- Without gifts, I do not know how to show care.
- When money is tight, I cannot be a good parent or spouse.
- Gifts prove love.
- No present means no love.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling loved only when gifts arrive and concluding that love is gifts.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing love is either expensive or absent.
- Mind reading: Assuming that someone’s lack of gifts means they do not care.
- Magnification: Treating a missing gift as proof of missing love.

Challenging questions

- How did my family show love, and with what?
- What else did love look like in my home besides gifts?
- What do I wish I had received besides things?

- How do I try to show love now, and does it match what people need?
- What does it cost people when love is shown only through money?
- What is one way I can show love this week that costs nothing?

Truth summary

> Gifts can be an expression of love, but they are not the same thing as love. Love is also time, words, presence, and faithfulness. I can receive and give love in ways that do not depend on what money can buy.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, General
- Giving
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Love, For Others
- Parenting

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Love Take Me Over — Steven Curtis Chapman
Receiving God's love can shape loving action instead of fear or performance.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Love is shown through things"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Love is shown through things." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How did my family show love?
- ☐ What did I want besides gifts?
- ☐ How do I show love now?
- ☐ What does the person I love need?
- ☐ What is one free way to show love today?
- ☐ Where have I measured love by things?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Gifts are one expression of love, not the whole of it.
- ☐ Time and presence are gifts.
- ☐ I can say "I love you" in words.
- ☐ I do not need to buy love.
- ☐ I am loved even when I have little to give.
- ☐ God's love is not measured in things.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 13:3
  "If I give all I possess to the poor and exult in the surrender of my body, but have not love, I gain nothing."
- ☐ 1 John 3:18
  "Little children, let us love not in word and speech, but in action and truth."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:17
  "Better a dish of vegetables where there is love than a fattened ox with hatred."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ How love showed up: Each day, write one way you gave or received love that did not cost money.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, 1 John 3:18 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can love in action and truth, with time and words as well as gifts.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Love, General" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ List five ways love has been shown to you. Circle the ones that did not involve money.
- ☐ Give one gift of time. Spend an hour with someone with no phone and no purchase.
- ☐ Say it out loud. Tell someone close to you, in words, what you appreciate about them.
- ☐ Ask a question. Ask someone you love, "How do you feel most cared for?" and listen.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Love is shown through things": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love without a price tag
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Love is shown through things.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for loving me without a price tag. Heal what I learned about love and things. Teach me to give and receive love through time, truth, and faithfulness. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.